



BUG BOUNTY FIELD GUIDE

Censys Target-Based Recon

CenQL Filters, Real-World Dorks & Automation for
Bug Bounty Hunters and Penetration Testers

- CenQL Query Language
- 2025 Edition

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1. Introduction to Censys

Censys is an internet-wide telemetry platform that continuously scans the entire IPv4 address space across all 65,535 ports, indexing hosts, services, and TLS/SSL certificates. Founded in 2015 at the University of Michigan, it is trusted by security teams, Fortune 500 companies, and governments worldwide. 🌐

For bug bounty hunters, Censys offers a unique advantage: **certificate-centric discovery**. Because Censys deeply indexes TLS certificate chains — including Subject Alternative Names (SANs), organizational fields, and issuer metadata — it excels at finding subdomains, related domains, and shadow IT assets that other search engines miss. 🗝️

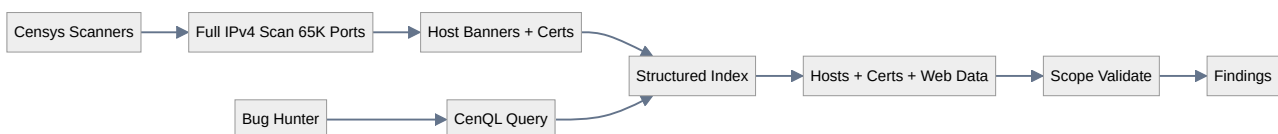
Why Censys Matters for Bug Bounty

8x More Coverage: Scans all 65K ports vs limited port scanning elsewhere. **Certificate Intelligence:** Deep SSL/TLS certificate analysis reveals hidden subdomains. **92% Accuracy:** Far fewer stale or dead results. **7x Faster Discovery:** New services detected in under 24 hours. **Passive Recon:** No packets sent to your target — completely silent.

How Censys Works

Censys operates three core datasets:

- **Hosts** — IPv4 scan data with services, banners, ports, and OS fingerprints
- **Certificates** — Full SSL/TLS certificate chains with SANs, org fields, and validation periods
- **Web Entities** — HTTP-specific data including response bodies, titles, headers, and technologies



Account Tiers

Table 1 Censys Account Tiers

Feature	Free	Paid (\$99-\$1000/mo)
Search queries	250/month	Unlimited tiers
API access	Limited	Full REST API

Certificate depth	Basic	Full chain + history
Data export	CSV/JSON limited	Bulk JSON/CSV export
Alerting	No	Host change notifications
Attack Surface Mgmt	No	Full ASM platform

2. CenQL: Core Search Filters

Censys Query Language (CenQL) is a structured, field-based search syntax. Unlike simple keyword searches, CenQL lets you query nested object fields with precision. Understanding the schema is essential for effective bug bounty reconnaissance. 🔍

2.1 Host & Network Filters

NETWORK

Table 2 Host & Network Fields

Filter	Description	Example
<code>ip</code>	IPv4 address	<code>ip: 203.0.113.42</code>
<code>services.port</code>	Open port number	<code>services.port: 9200</code>
<code>services.service_name</code>	Protocol/service name	<code>services.service_name: HTTP</code>
<code>autonomous_system.asn</code>	AS number	<code>autonomous_system.asn: 15169</code>
<code>autonomous_system.organization</code>	AS org name	<code>autonomous_system.organization: "Google LLC"</code>
<code>location.country</code>	Country code	<code>location.country: US</code>
<code>location.city</code>	City name	<code>location.city: "San Francisco"</code>
<code>operating_system.name</code>	OS name	<code>operating_system.name: "Windows"</code>

2.2 Service & Certificate Filters

CERTIFICATE

Table 3 Service & Certificate Fields

Filter	Description	Example
<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names</code>	Cert SANS/domains	<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names: target.com</code>
<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.subject.organization</code>	Org in cert subject	<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.subject.organization: "Apple Inc"</code>
<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.issuer.organization</code>	Cert issuer org	<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.issuer.organization: "DigiCert"</code>
<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.validity_period.end</code>	Cert expiry	<code>services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.validity_period.end: [2025-01-01 to 2025-06-01]</code>
<code>services.tls.certificates.chain.fingerprint</code>	Cert fingerprint	<code>services.tls.certificates.chain.fingerprint_sha256: "abc123..."</code>
<code>dns.names</code>	DNS names associated	<code>dns.names: target.com</code>
<code>services.tls.version</code>	TLS version	<code>services.tls.version: TLSv1_2</code>

The SSL Org Trick

Censys indexes the `Organization (0=)` field from SSL certificates. Searching by org name finds **all domains** owned by a company — including acquisitions and shadow IT. Example: `"0=Apple Inc"` reveals `apple.com`, `shazamcloud.com`, `claris.com`, `apple-dns.cn`, and more.

2.3 HTTP / Web Filters

WEB APP

Table 4 HTTP & Web Fields

Filter	Description	Example
<code>services.http.response.html_title</code>	HTML page title	<code>services.http.response.html_title: "Login"</code>
<code>services.http.response.status_code</code>	HTTP status code	<code>services.http.response.status_code: 200</code>
<code>services.http.response.body</code>	Response body content	<code>services.http.response.body: "admin"</code>
<code>services.http.response.headers.name</code>	HTTP header name	<code>services.http.response.headers.name: "X-Jenkins"</code>
<code>services.http.response.headers.value</code>	HTTP header value	<code>services.http.response.headers.value: "nginx"</code>
<code>services.http.response.protocol</code>	HTTP version	<code>services.http.response.protocol: "HTTP/2"</code>
<code>services.http.response.favicons.md5_hash</code>	Favicon hash	<code>services.http.response.favicons.md5_hash: "f3418a443..."</code>
<code>website.domain</code>	Website domain	<code>website.domain: target.com</code>

2.4 Software & Technology Filters

FINGERPRINTING

Table 5 Software & Technology Fields

Filter	Description	Example
<code>services.software.vendor</code>	Software vendor	<code>services.software.vendor: Jenkins</code>

<code>services.software.product</code>	Product name	<code>services.software.product: "Apache httpd"</code>
<code>services.software.version</code>	Product version	<code>services.software.version: "2.4.41"</code>
<code>services.cpe</code>	CPE identifier	<code>services.cpe: "cpe:/a:apache:httpd:2.4.41"</code>
<code>services.software.uniform_resource_identifiers</code>	URIs from banner	<code>services.software.uniform_resource_identifiers: "admin"</code>

CenQL Boolean Operators

Use `AND`, `OR`, `NOT`, and parentheses for complex queries. Use `[]` for ranges. Use `{}` for sets. Example: `(services.port: {80, 443}) AND services.http.response.status_code: [300 to 399]`

3. Bug Bounty Dorks by Category

These are real-world CenQL queries crafted specifically for bug bounty reconnaissance. Every query targets a specific exposure type with precise field targeting. 🎯

3.1 Exposed Admin Panels & Consoles

HIGH-IMPACT

ADMIN Jenkins CI/CD Dashboard

Unprotected Jenkins instances expose build pipelines, secrets, and script console access.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND  
services.http.response.headers.name:"X-Jenkins"
```

ADMIN Apache Tomcat Manager

Tomcat manager interfaces that allow WAR deployment for remote code execution.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Apache Tomcat" AND  
services.http.response.body:"manager"
```

ADMIN phpMyAdmin Login Page

phpMyAdmin interfaces providing full database control with weak or default credentials.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"phpMyAdmin" AND  
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names: target.com
```

ADMIN Kubernetes Dashboard

Exposed Kubernetes dashboards may allow pod execution and cluster takeover.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Kubernetes Dashboard" AND  
services.http.response.body:"Kubernetes"
```

ADMIN Grafana Monitoring

Grafana instances expose server metrics, logs, and sometimes admin panels.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Grafana" AND services.software.vendor: Grafana
```

ADMIN Kibana Elasticsearch

Kibana interfaces reveal log data and may allow Elasticsearch query execution.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Kibana" AND services.port: 5601
```

ADMIN Docker Registry API

Unauthenticated Docker registries leak container images and potentially source code.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Docker Registry" AND services.port: 5000
```


ADMIN **MinIO Storage Console**

MinIO object storage may expose buckets and admin interfaces without auth.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"MinIO" Browser" AND  
services.http.response.body:"MinIO"
```

3.2 Databases & Data Stores

SENSITIVE DATA

DATABASE **Open Elasticsearch**

Unauthenticated Elasticsearch instances expose all indexed data. High-severity P1 finding.

```
services.service_name: ELASTICSEARCH AND services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names:  
target.com
```

DATABASE **Exposed MongoDB**

MongoDB without authentication exposes entire databases over the internet.

```
services.service_name: MONGODB AND services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names:  
target.com
```

DATABASE **Redis Unprotected**

Redis instances without AUTH expose cached data and may allow config rewrite for RCE.

```
services.service_name: REDIS AND autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company"
```

DATABASE **CouchDB / Cassandra**

NoSQL databases with default or missing authentication expose full datasets.

```
(services.software.product: CouchDB OR services.software.product: Cassandra) AND  
autonomous_system.organization:"Target"
```

LEAKED **Git Config & Source Code**

Exposed .git/config files leak repository URLs, paths, and sometimes credentials.

```
services.http.response.body:"[core]" AND  
services.http.response.body:"repositoryformatversion"
```

LEAKED **Open Directory Listings**

Directory indexes expose backups, configs, databases, and sensitive files.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Index of *" AND  
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company"
```

3.3 Cloud & DevOps Exposure

CLOUD INFRA

CLOUD **Swagger / OpenAPI Docs**

Exposed Swagger UI reveals API endpoints, parameters, and sometimes test tokens.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"Swagger UI" AND  
services.http.response.body:"swagger-ui"
```

CLOUD **GraphQL Playground**

GraphQL introspection enabled allows full schema discovery and data over-extraction.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"GraphQL Playground" AND  
services.http.response.body:"graphql"
```

CLOUD AWS EC2 IMDSv1

EC2 metadata service v1 exposure can leak IAM credentials via crafted requests.

```
services.http.response.body:"iam/security-credentials" AND  
services.http.response.status_code: 200
```

CLOUD S3 Bucket Listings

Misconfigured S3 buckets with public ListBucketResult XML exposed to the internet.

```
services.http.response.body:"ListBucketResult" AND  
services.http.response.body:"s3.amazonaws.com"
```

CLOUD Firebase / Cloud Configs

Exposed mobile app configs and cloud function endpoints in HTTP responses.

```
services.http.response.body:"firebaseio.com" OR  
services.http.response.body:"appspot.com"
```

DEVOPS Docker-Compose / .env Files

Configuration files exposed in web roots leak credentials, API keys, and secrets.

```
services.http.response.body:"DB_PASSWORD" AND services.http.response.body:"APP_KEY"
```

3.4 Vulnerable Services & CVEs

CVE HUNTING

CVE Log4j / Log4Shell (CVE-2021-44228)

Services running Java with Log4j versions vulnerable to the infamous JNDI RCE.

```
services.software.vendor: "Apache" AND services.http.response.body:"log4j" AND  
autonomous_system.organization:"Target"
```

CVE F5 BIG-IP (CVE-2022-1388)

BIG-IP iControl REST auth bypass leading to critical unauthenticated RCE.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"BIG-IP" AND services.software.vendor: "F5" AND  
services.port: 443
```

CVE GitLab CE RCE (CVE-2021-22205)

GitLab CE with ExifTool vulnerable to image upload RCE via DjVu files.

```
services.http.response.html_title:"GitLab" AND services.http.response.body:"GitLab  
Community Edition"
```

CVE Spring4Shell (CVE-2022-22965)

Spring Framework on Tomcat with Java 9+ — vulnerable to WAR file write RCE.

```
services.http.response.body:"Spring Boot" AND services.software.product: "Apache  
Tomcat"
```

CVE PAN-OS GlobalProtect XSS (CVE-2025-0133)

Palo Alto Networks GlobalProtect with reflected XSS in getConfig.esp endpoint.

```
services.software.vendor: "Palo Alto Networks" AND  
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names: target.com
```

CVE Apache Struts (CVE-2017-5638)

Apache Struts with OGNL expression injection — classic but still present on legacy systems.

```
services.software.product: "Apache Struts" AND services.http.response.status_code:  
200
```

3.5 Authentication & Redirects

WEB LOGIC

AUTH Login Pages Discovery

Find all authentication panels for a target — SSO, VPN, admin, and application logins.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND  
services.http.response.html_title: {"Login", "Log in", "Signin", "Sign in",  
"Authentication"}
```

REDIRECT Suspicious HTTP Redirects

3XX redirects often point to internal endpoints, staging, or unauthenticated resources.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND  
services.http.response.status_code: [300 to 399]
```

AUTH Basic Auth Endpoints

HTTP Basic Authentication prompts with weak or default credentials.

```
services.http.response.headers.name: "WWW-Authenticate" AND  
services.http.response.headers.value: "Basic"
```

LOGIC Non-Standard HTTP Ports

HTTP services on unusual ports often serve dev, admin, or legacy content.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND services.service_name: HTTP AND  
NOT services.port: {80, 443, 8080, 8443}
```

4. Targeting Specific Organizations

Censys shines when hunting specific targets. Its certificate intelligence and AS org mapping let you discover assets other tools completely miss. 🌍

Primary Domain Discovery via SSL Org

The most powerful Censys technique for bug bounty is the SSL Organization field search. All certificates issued to a company contain their legal name in the `0=` field. Censys indexes this, letting you find every domain that belongs to an organization — including acquisitions and forgotten infrastructure.

STEP-BY-STEP: DOMAIN DISCOVERY

```
# Step 1: Find the SSL org name
openssl s_client -connect target.com:443 -servername target.com /dev/null | openssl
x509 -noout -subject -issuer
# Look for: 0=Target Inc.

# Step 2: Search Censys by org field
"0=Target Inc"

# Step 3: Exclude known domains iteratively to find hidden ones
"0=Target Inc" and not "target.com" and not "amazonaws.com"

# Step 4: Further refine with additional exclusions
"0=Target Inc" and not "target.com" and not "amazonaws.com" and not "cloudflare.com"
```

Certificate SAN Enumeration

SUBDOMAIN DISCOVERY VIA CERTIFICATES

```
# Find all subdomains via certificate SANs
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names: target.com

# Wildcard certificate enumeration
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names: "*.target.com"

# Find related domains sharing the same cert
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.names:                "*.target.com"                AND
services.tls.certificates.leaf_data.issuer.organization: "DigiCert"
```

AS Org + Service Filtering

RECON PHP-Powered Services

Find PHP-based sites for a target to focus on PHP-specific vulnerabilities.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND services.software.product:"PHP"
```

RECON Technology Stack Mapping

Discover the full technology footprint of a target for focused testing.

```
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND  
services.http.response.headers.name: "X-Powered-By"
```

Favicon Hash Matching

Favicon Hash on Censys

Censys indexes `services.http.response.favicons.md5_hash`. Compute the MD5 of a target's favicon, then search Censys for all hosts using that same icon — revealing shadow deployments, acquired services, and forgotten instances.

FAVICON HASH WORKFLOW

```
# 1. Get favicon MD5  
curl -s https://target.com/favicon.ico | md5sum  
# Returns: f3418a443e7d2... -  
  
# 2. Search Censys  
services.http.response.favicons.md5_hash: "f3418a443e7d2..."  
  
# 3. Narrow by org  
autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND  
services.http.response.favicons.md5_hash: "f3418a443e7d2..."
```

5. Censys CLI & API Automation

Censys provides a Python SDK and REST API for automation. For bug bounty hunters, this means repeatable reconnaissance pipelines that scale across dozens of targets. 🤖

Python SDK Setup

INSTALLATION

```
# Install Censys Python SDK
pip install censys

# Set API credentials (get from https://search.censys.io/account/api)
export CENSYS_API_ID=your_api_id
export CENSYS_API_SECRET=your_api_secret
```

Host Search API Script

PYTHON: TARGETED HOST ENUMERATION

```
from censys.search import CensysHosts

# Initialize client
h = CensysHosts()

# CenQL query for target org + specific service
query = 'autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company" AND services.service_name:HTTP'

# Paginate through results
for page in h.search(query, per_page=100):
    for host in page:
        ip = host["ip"]
        services = host.get("services", [])
        for svc in services:
            port = svc.get("port")
            name = svc.get("service_name")
            print(f"{ip}:{port} ({name})")
```

Certificate Search API

PYTHON: CERTIFICATE SUBDOMAIN DISCOVERY


```

from censys.search import CensysCertificates

c = CensysCertificates()

# Find all certs with target domain in SANs
query = 'names: target.com'

for cert in c.search(query, per_page=100):
    names = cert.get("names", [])
    fingerprint = cert.get("fingerprint_sha256", "N/A")
    print(f"Cert: {fingerprint}")
    print(f" Domains: {' ', '.join(names)}")

```

One-Liner CLI Workflows

CLI ONE-LINERS

```

# Export host IPs for a target org
python3 -c "from censys.search import CensysHosts; h=CensysHosts(); [print(x['ip']) for p in h.search('autonomous_system.organization:\\"Target Inc\\"') for x in p]" | tee target_ips.txt

# Get all certificate SANs for a domain
python3 -c "from censys.search import CensysCertificates; c=CensysCertificates(); [print(n) for p in c.search('names: target.com') for x in p for n in x.get('names', [])]" | sort -u | tee target_domains.txt

# Monitor for new Elasticsearch instances
python3 -c "
from censys.search import CensysHosts
h = CensysHosts()
q = 'services.service_name: ELASTICSEARCH AND autonomous_system.organization:\\"Target\\"'
for page in h.search(q, per_page=50):
    for host in page:
        print(f'[] ES at {host["ip"]}\'')
" | notify -id censys-es-alerts

```

6. Censys vs Shodan

Both tools are essential in a bug bounty hunter's arsenal. Understanding their strengths lets you choose the right tool for each reconnaissance phase. 🏴‍☠️

Table 6 Censys vs Shodan Comparison

Dimension	Censys	Shodan
-----------	--------	--------

Port Coverage	All 65K ports (8x more)	Top ~100 ports primarily
Data Freshness	<24 hours median	~3 days average
Accuracy	92% live services	68% live services
Certificate Depth	Full chain + history	Basic cert data
Query Language	CenQL (structured fields)	Simple filters
Best For	Certificate OSINT, org mapping, accuracy	IoT, quick checks, screenshots
Free Tier	250 queries/month	100 API credits/month
Price	\$99-\$1000/mo	\$49/mo membership

When to Use Which

Table 7 Tool Selection Guide

Task	Best Tool	Why
Find all company domains	Censys	SSL org field search is unmatched
Certificate SAN enumeration	Censys	Deepest certificate indexing
IoT/webcam discovery	Shodan	Superior IoT device database
Screenshots of web UIs	Shodan	Built-in screenshot capture
High-accuracy service data	Censys	92% accuracy vs 68%
Vulnerability correlation	Both	Cross-reference for validation
Non-standard port hunting	Censys	Full 65K port coverage

Pro Strategy: Use Both

Run the same query on both platforms. Censys often finds certificates and subdomains Shodan misses, while Shodan surfaces IoT and obscure devices with screenshots. Cross-referencing results between both yields the most complete attack surface map.

7. Integration & Workflow

Censys integrates seamlessly into modern bug bounty reconnaissance pipelines. Here are proven workflows used by top hunters. [🔗](#)

The Censys → Subfinder → Httpx Pipeline

INTEGRATED RECON

```
# Phase 1: Censys certificate discovery for subdomains
python3 -c "
from censys.search import CensysCertificates
c = CensysCertificates()
[print(n) for p in c.search('names: target.com') for x in p for n in x.get('names',[])]
" | sort -u | tee censys_subs.txt

# Phase 2: Passive subdomain expansion with Subfinder
subfinder -d target.com -all -silent | anew censys_subs.txt

# Phase 3: Resolve to IPs
cat censys_subs.txt | dnsx -a -silent | tee subs_resolved.txt

# Phase 4: Validate live HTTP + grab metadata
cat censys_subs.txt | httpx -title -status-code -tech-detect -o live_http.txt

# Phase 5: Censys host lookup for interesting services
for ip in $(cat subs_resolved.txt | cut -d' ' -f2 | sort -u); do
    python3 -c "from censys.search import CensysHosts; h=CensysHosts();
r=h.view('$ip'); print(r)" >> censys_hosts.jsonl
done
```

Censys + Nuclei for CVE Validation

CVE VALIDATION CHAIN

```
# Step 1: Censys query for product + target
python3 -c "
from censys.search import CensysHosts
h = CensysHosts()
q = 'services.software.vendor: Jenkins AND autonomous_system.organization:\"Target\"'
for p in h.search(q):
    for host in p:
        for svc in host.get('services',[]):
            if svc.get('port') in [80,443,8080,8443]:
                proto = 'https' if svc['port'] in [443,8443] else 'http'
                print(f'{proto}://{host[\"ip\"]}:{svc[\"port\"]}')
" | tee jenkins_targets.txt

# Step 2: Validate with httpx
cat jenkins_targets.txt | httpprobe | tee live_jenkins.txt

# Step 3: Nuclei CVE templates
cat live_jenkins.txt | nuclei -t cves/ -tags jenkins -severity critical,high
```

Continuous Monitoring

CENSYS MONITOR SCRIPT

```
#!/usr/bin/env python3
# censys_monitor.py - Alert on new target assets

from censys.search import CensysHosts
import json, datetime

h = CensysHosts()
TARGET_ORG = "Target Company"
QUERY = f'autonomous_system.organization:"{TARGET_ORG}"'
STATE_FILE = "censys_state.json"

try:
    with open(STATE_FILE) as f:
        known = set(json.load(f))
except:
    known = set()

current = set()
for page in h.search(QUERY, per_page=100):
    for host in page:
        current.add(host["ip"])

new = current - known
if new:
    print(f"[{datetime.datetime.now()}] NEW ASSETS: {len(new)}")
    for ip in new:
        print(f"  - {ip}")
    # Notify or trigger scans here

with open(STATE_FILE, 'w') as f:
    json.dump(list(current), f)
```

8. Best Practices & Legal

Validation Checklist

Table 8 Before Reporting

Step	Action	Why
1	Confirm asset ownership via AS org or cert data	Censys org field may include CDNs/resellers
2	Verify exposure is within program scope	Out-of-scope reports waste time
3	Check if already known or reported	Duplicates don't earn rewards

4	Validate exploitability (don't just trust scan data)	Confirmed = higher severity/payout
5	Document the exact CenQL query	Shows methodology to triagers
6	Include Censys result timestamp	Proves finding recency and accuracy

Writing Strong Reports

Report Template: Censys Finding

Title: [P1] Unauthenticated Elasticsearch Instance at 203.0.113.42

Description: During passive reconnaissance using Censys, I discovered an exposed Elasticsearch instance belonging to [Target Company].

Censys Query: `services.service_name: ELASTICSEARCH AND autonomous_system.organization:"Target Company"`

Host Data: IP 203.0.113.42, Port 9200, Service confirmed live on [Date].

Impact: Unauthenticated access allows reading, writing, and deleting all indexed data. An attacker could dump sensitive records or destroy the dataset.

Remediation: Enable X-Pack security / authentication. Restrict to internal network. Implement firewall rules.

Legal & Ethical Guidelines

Do not exploit without written permission. Censys is passive, but accessing discovered systems without authorization violates laws like CFAA and Computer Misuse Act. **Only report to programs where you have explicit scope. Never modify data, delete records, or execute commands on target systems. Follow responsible disclosure timelines.**

Recommended Resources

- **Censys Search** — search.censys.io (Official platform)
- **Censys Python SDK** — github.com/censys/censys-python
- **Censys API Docs** — docs.censys.com (CenQL reference)
- **Intigriti Blog** — intigriti.com/researchers/blog (Censys vs Shodan guide)
- **ExploitDB** — exploit-db.com (CVE to exploit mapping)
- **Nuclei Templates** — github.com/projectdiscovery/nuclei-templates